

Take Full Responsibility: Pat in Her Own Words

Coach Pat Summitt

You know, I always tell the story about when I came home and he (my son Tyler) was 9 years old and I go in and he's upset and I walk in the room and I said, 'Tyler, what's wrong with you?' And he goes, 'I got cut.'

Well, my first thought is—What coach in East Tennessee would cut my son? I mean, think about it. You know, put him at the end of the bench but give him a uniform.

And then I guess the coach came out in me and I looked at Tyler and I said *(voice trails off)* ...

He had a basketball under each arm and he was crying so hard and I said, 'Tyler, if you wear out both of those basketballs I promise you, I guarantee, you will make the team next year. Do you hear me?'

And he goes, 'Yes, ma'am.'

And I said, 'Well, then let's get it done.'

And he goes, 'Mom, will you help me?'

I said, 'Son, I will help you but I will not start your engine. You must start your engine every day. Do you understand that?'

And he goes, 'Yes, ma'am.'

(It was) a defining moment in his life. It changed him. It changed his focus, it changed his work ethic, his drive, and I haven't had to motivate him since then. Not at all. It's a pretty incredible story.

But, you know, as I look back and I tell people about it they're like, 'Well, it's not that easy, is it?' And I said, 'It is, if you're driven to be successful.'

And I've always been driven to be successful. I hate to lose.